Employee Attrition Prediction Using Non-Probabilistic and Probabilistic Classification with Feature Selection



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Practical Applications 1 and 2 — Machine Learning

Abstract

Employee attrition is studied as a binary supervised classification problem using 1,470 observations from the IBM HR Analytics Employee Attrition & Performance dataset.

Practical Applications 1 and 2 compare K-NN, Decision Tree, Support Vector Machine, Neural Network and RIPPER classifiers with Mixed Naive Bayes, Logistic Regression, Linear and Quadratic Discriminant Analysis. Each family is evaluated with all valid predictors, univariate and multivariate filters, and a forward-selection wrapper; Bagging, AdaBoost and Stacking extend the probabilistic comparison.

Predictive performance is estimated through stratified 10-fold cross-validation, with preprocessing and selection fitted within each outer training fold; the tree-based wrapper uses internal five-fold selection; RIPPER uses a bounded three-step search with two internal folds.

The full-feature Neural Network leads PA1 in F1 (0.4738). In PA2, full-feature Logistic Regression obtains F1 0.5373 and the highest AUC (0.8375), while Stacking marginally increases F1 to 0.5394 and achieves the lowest probability-vector Brier score (0.1846). Full-feature Mixed Naive Bayes provides the highest PA2 recall (0.6453). Feature selection offers smaller representations but does not outperform the strongest complete-feature models.

Recurring predictors, including overtime, job level, stock-option level and company tenure, support predictive interpretation without implying causality.

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1 Introduction

Employee attrition describes employees leaving an organisation. In this application, recorded employee characteristics are used to distinguish employees who leave from those who remain, giving a supervised binary classification task. The analysis concerns associations in the available data rather than explanations of individual decisions to leave.

Feature selection can reduce dimensionality, remove irrelevant or redundant information and make the retained employee characteristics easier to interpret. These potential benefits need to be assessed against predictive performance: a smaller representation need not preserve all useful information.

This integrated study evaluates five PA1 classifiers and four PA2 probabilistic classifiers under four feature-selection strategies: all valid predictors, univariate filtering, multivariate filtering and wrapper selection. PA2 also evaluates three metaclassifiers. The research question is: *Which employee characteristics repeatedly support attrition prediction, and how do classifier choice and feature selection affect predictive performance, minority-class sensitivity and probability quality?* Dimensionality and model complexity inform the comparison.

2 Problem Description

The IBM HR Analytics Employee Attrition & Performance dataset contains 1,470 employee observations and 35 original columns, including the binary target `Attrition`. Its distribution is summarised in Table 1. The dataset is distributed through Kaggle [1]. Predictors cover demographics (age and marital status), professional attributes (department and job role), compensation (monthly income and stock options), satisfaction and involvement, experience (working years and company tenure), and working conditions (overtime and business travel).

Table 1: Dataset characteristics and target distribution.

Characteristic	Value
Observations	1,470
Original columns, including target	35
Valid original predictors after removal	30
Numerical / categorical predictors	23 / 7
Missing values	0
`No`: employee remains	1,233 (83.88%)
`Yes`: employee leaves	237 (16.12%)

Both applications use this dataset and define `Yes` as the positive class. Its minority status means that accuracy alone does not adequately describe attrition detection: always predicting `No` would obtain 83.88% accuracy while detecting no attrition cases. The identifier `EmployeeNumber` and the constant columns `EmployeeCount`, `Over18` and `StandardHours` are removed during preprocessing. With 30 valid predictors and 1,470 observations, the dataset exceeds the assignment's minimum of 15 variables and 100 observations. The numerical/categorical counts describe raw storage types; PA2 additionally distinguishes continuous and ordinal predictors for model-specific processing.

3 Methodology

3.1 PA1: Non-Probabilistic Classification

3.1.1 Data Preprocessing

The four non-predictive columns identified above are removed, leaving 30 original predictors. No imputation is needed because there are no missing values. The target is encoded as `No`=0 and `Yes`=1. For K-NN, Decision Tree, SVM and Neural Network, the 23 numerical predictors are standardised using `StandardScaler`; the seven categorical predictors are encoded using `OneHotEncoder` with `handle_unknown="ignore"`. Integer variables representing ordinal levels retain their ordered numerical representation. The complete encoded representation contains 51 transformed features.

For K-NN, Decision Tree, SVM and Neural Network, a scikit-learn `Pipeline` [4] combines preprocessing, optional selection and classification; RIPPER uses explicit DataFrame fits and predictions. Fitted preprocessing from structural inspection is not reused for evaluation. Transformations and selectors are fitted on each outer training fold, and then applied to its held-out fold.

3.1.2 Classification Algorithms

Five classifiers are evaluated in each of the four PA1 experiments: K-NN, Decision Tree, SVM, Neural Network and RIPPER. K-NN classifies from neighbouring observations; Decision Tree uses successive feature splits; SVM constructs a separating boundary; Neural Network learns a multilayer representation; and RIPPER induces an IF–THEN rule set. The implementations are `KNeighborsClassifier()`, `DecisionTreeClassifier` (random seed 42), `SVC()`, `MLPClassifier` (random seed 42; maximum 2,000 iterations) and `wittgenstein` 0.3.5 RIPPER (random seed 42) [2]. Other parameters remain at their defaults. The tree is scikit-learn's implementation, not an exact implementation of ID3 or C4.5. Hyperparameters are not tuned, and no resampling or class weighting is applied.

RIPPER grows, prunes and optimises rules using training data. It preserves nominal strings and unscaled numerical values; numeric bins are learned on training data only and reused for validation. Under the two filters, it uses the same 15 selected transformed columns as the other classifiers, with numerical columns restored to original units and selected dummy indicators kept binary. Its wrapper instead searches original predictors with two inner stratified folds, F1 scoring and at most three forward additions, retaining the best prefix. Every candidate refits RIPPER and discretisation within its inner training split. Fold-level rules, selections and metrics are retained for interpretation. Feature counts from original predictors and transformed columns are not directly comparable.

3.2 Shared Evaluation Protocol and Metrics

Every configuration is evaluated using `StratifiedKFold` with ten shuffled folds and random seed 42. Stratification approximately preserves class proportions. Each outer held-out fold is excluded from fitting preprocessing, selecting features and training the classifier, providing an honest estimate for each fixed configuration. Reported scores are arithmetic means of the ten held-out-fold scores.

Accuracy measures the proportion of correct predictions. Precision (positive predictive value) measures the proportion of predicted attrition cases that are positive; recall (sensitivity) measures the proportion of actual attrition cases detected. Specificity measures the proportion of negative cases correctly identified. F1-measure is the harmonic mean of precision and recall. Positive-class metrics refer to `Attrition=Yes`. PA1 records accuracy, precision, recall, F1 and balanced

accuracy; the latter averages sensitivity and specificity and is retained as a supplementary PA1 measure.

PA2 reports accuracy, precision, recall, specificity, F1, area under the ROC curve (AUC), and Brier score. AUC evaluates discrimination across decision thresholds. Brier evaluates squared error in the complete predicted class-probability vector:

$$B = \frac{1}{n}\sum_{i=1}^{n}\sum_{c\in\{0,1\}}\left(p_{ic} - \mathbf{1}\{y_i = c\}\right)^2 .$$

Lower values indicate better probability predictions. This implementation is twice the binary Brier score computed from the positive-class probability alone. Brier reflects both calibration and discrimination, rather than calibration alone. Balanced accuracy is not a primary PA2 metric. Predictions use the implemented classifiers' default decision rules; thresholds are not optimised for recall.

3.3 PA1: Feature Selection Strategies

All Features. All 30 valid original predictors are retained. K-NN, Decision Tree, SVM and Neural Network receive 51 transformed columns; RIPPER receives the original predictor columns with its training-fold discretisation.

Univariate Filter. After preprocessing, `SelectKBest` with `f_classif` and $k = 15$ retains the 15 transformed features with the highest individual ANOVA F-scores. It assesses association with the target separately for each feature [3].

Multivariate Filter. The existing custom greedy selector retains 15 transformed features. It first selects the feature with the greatest estimated mutual information with the target. Subsequently it maximises target mutual information minus the mean absolute Pearson correlation with already selected features. Mutual information is computed using `mutual_info_classif` with random seed 42. This custom relevance–redundancy selector measures redundancy by correlation rather than mutual information.

Wrapper. For K-NN, Decision Tree, SVM and Neural Network, `SequentialFeatureSelector` performs forward selection of 15 transformed features using a `DecisionTreeClassifier` with random seed 42, F1 scoring and internal five-fold CV [3]. RIPPER uses the bounded original-predictor search described above. Selection is nested within the outer ten-fold evaluation: inner CV chooses the subset, while outer held-out folds estimate predictive performance. For the tree-based selector, preprocessing is fitted on the outer training fold before inner CV and is not refitted within each inner split. The outer test fold remains excluded throughout.

For interpretation only, separate selector pipelines are fitted to the full dataset to export selected-feature lists. These fits do not generate the reported predictive scores. Their overlap describes agreement across the three strategies in these descriptive fits, rather than selection frequency across CV folds. One-hot categories are mapped back to their original variables.

3.4 PA2: Probabilistic Classification

3.4.1 Model-Specific Representations

PA2 retains the same 30 valid original predictors and target. One representative implementation is used per family. Mixed Naive Bayes estimates Gaussian class-conditional distributions for continuous predictors and discrete class-conditional probabilities with Laplace smoothing ($\alpha = 1$) for ordinal and nominal predictors. It combines these contributions under conditional independence given the class.

Logistic Regression models the log-odds of attrition as an additive function of its transformed predictors. Its pipeline applies `StandardScaler` to continuous and ordinal variables and `OneHotEncoder` with one reference category to nominal variables. `LogisticRegression` uses a maximum of 2,000 iterations and random seed 42, with remaining parameters at defaults.

LDA and QDA model class-conditional distributions with shared and class-specific covariance matrices, respectively. Their pipelines standardise numerical/ordinal predictors and retain one numerically encoded column per nominal predictor, avoiding the rank deficiency introduced by expanded dummy variables. These nominal codes do not imply a meaningful order; their numerical use is a representation limitation. The implementations are `LinearDiscriminantAnalysis()` and `QuadraticDiscriminantAnalysis()`. Thus, the families do not receive an identical transformed matrix. Every representation is fitted using training data only.

3.4.2 Feature Selection on Original Predictors

All Features. All 30 valid original predictors are retained before model-specific preprocessing.

Univariate Filter. A type-aware selector evaluates continuous predictors with ANOVA F-statistics and ordinal/nominal predictors with mutual information. Scores are standardised separately within these two families because their scales differ. The 15 highest-ranked original predictors are retained inside each training fold, before model-specific transformation.

Multivariate Filter. The implemented Correlation-based Feature Selection (CFS) evaluates subset relevance to the target and redundancy between predictors using Symmetrical Uncertainty. Continuous variables are discretised into up to five quantile bins using training data only for this criterion; selected predictors retain their original values for classification. For a subset of size k, the merit is

$$M = \frac{k\overline{SU}_{Xy}}{\sqrt{k + k(k-1)\overline{SU}_{XX}}},$$

where the averages describe predictor–target association and pairwise predictor redundancy. Greedy forward search considers up to 15 original predictors and retains the subset with the highest merit found. This CFS procedure differs from PA1's custom relevance–redundancy selector.

Wrapper. Classifier-specific sequential forward selection searches up to 15 original predictors and retains the subset with the highest internal mean F1. Each classifier conducts its own search in each outer training fold. Internal stratified five-fold CV evaluates candidate model pipelines, refitting preprocessing within each inner training split. The selected pipeline is then fitted on the outer training data and evaluated on its held-out fold using the shared ten-fold protocol. Feature search and final performance estimation are therefore separated; PA1's common tree-based wrapper is not reused.

Separate full-data PA2 filter fits are descriptive only. Fold-level selections are also recorded to assess recurrence under the evaluation protocol, providing information distinct from PA1's descriptive agreement counts.

3.4.3 Metaclassifiers

Representative Bagging, AdaBoost and Stacking configurations are evaluated with all valid predictors. Bagging aggregates 100 Decision Trees; AdaBoost combines 100 decision stumps (trees with maximum depth one). Stacking uses Logistic Regression and LDA as base learners and

Logistic Regression as the final estimator, trained on internally generated probability predictions with five-fold CV. QDA was excluded from stacking because covariance estimation became numerically unstable in its internal folds.

The ensemble pipelines standardise numerical/ordinal predictors and one-hot encode nominal predictors with a reference category. This shared ensemble representation differs from the standalone LDA/QDA representation. Preprocessing is fitted on each outer training fold before the ensemble's internal operations; it is not independently refitted inside stacking's internal folds. The outer held-out fold remains excluded, so the reported ensemble scores are honest outer-fold estimates, although the internal stacking representation has this limitation. Ensemble variants beyond these representatives are not evaluated.

4 Results

4.1 PA1: Non-Probabilistic Classification

4.1.1 All Features

With all features, the Neural Network has the highest F1 (0.4738) and balanced accuracy (0.6765). SVM has the highest accuracy and precision but much lower recall (0.2241). The remaining models have lower F1; their complete metrics appear in Table 2.

4.1.2 Univariate Filter

Decision Tree leads this strategy in F1 (0.3809) and balanced accuracy (0.6347). It and K-NN improve relative to their all-feature results; SVM, Neural Network and RIPPER lose F1 after univariate selection.

4.1.3 Multivariate Filter

The Neural Network leads this strategy in F1 (0.3902), followed by Decision Tree (0.3748). K-NN, SVM and RIPPER fall below their all-feature F1 scores; SVM recall drops to 0.0511.

4.1.4 Wrapper

The RIPPER wrapper leads all reduced configurations in F1 (0.3996) and balanced accuracy (0.6557), selecting a mean of 2.6 original predictors per outer fold. Under the tree-based wrapper, Neural Network has the highest F1 (0.3919), while K-NN improves from 0.2115 to 0.3146 relative to its all-feature F1. None of these configurations exceeds the full-feature Neural Network.

4.1.5 Comparison Across Strategies

Table 2 reports the ten-fold means for all 20 configurations; Figure 1 shows the F1 pattern. The full-feature Neural Network remains ahead of the best reduced configuration, the RIPPER wrapper. K-NN, Decision Tree, SVM and Neural Network retain 15 of 51 transformed columns under selection, a 70.59% reduction. The corresponding RIPPER wrapper count is measured in original predictors.

4.1.6 Selected Variables

Table 3 reports original variables retained by at least two strategies in the separate full-data interpretation fits. Seven original variables appear in all three strategies. A categorical variable is counted as selected when at least one of its dummy features is retained, even when strategies choose different categories of that variable.

Table 2: PA1 performance across four feature-selection strategies and five classifiers. Entries are ten-fold means; BA denotes balanced accuracy. Bold indicates the highest F1 within each strategy.

Model	Acc.	Prec.	Rec.	F1	BA
All Features					
Neural Network	0.8490	0.5492	0.4219	**0.4738**	0.6765
Decision Tree	0.7925	0.3604	0.3670	0.3620	0.6206
SVM	0.8653	0.8363	0.2241	0.3461	0.6064
RIPPER	0.8306	0.4507	0.2147	0.2866	0.5818
K-NN	0.8442	0.5412	0.1350	0.2115	0.5577
Univariate					
Decision Tree	0.7789	0.3546	0.4219	**0.3809**	0.6347
Neural Network	0.8163	0.4167	0.3293	0.3642	0.6197
K-NN	0.8463	0.5761	0.2062	0.2968	0.5877
SVM	0.8571	0.7933	0.1692	0.2737	0.5793
RIPPER	0.8415	0.6102	0.1558	0.2316	0.5645
Multivariate					
Neural Network	0.8245	0.4501	0.3534	**0.3902**	0.6341
Decision Tree	0.7898	0.3652	0.3958	0.3748	0.6306
RIPPER	0.8429	0.5439	0.1558	0.2280	0.5653
K-NN	0.8354	0.4524	0.1018	0.1632	0.5391
SVM	0.8442	0.5667	0.0511	0.0910	0.5239
Wrapper					
RIPPER	0.7823	0.3640	0.4687	**0.3996**	0.6557
Neural Network	0.8401	0.5278	0.3165	0.3919	0.6286
Decision Tree	0.7782	0.3358	0.3879	0.3594	0.6205
K-NN	0.8395	0.5043	0.2364	0.3146	0.5959
SVM	0.8456	0.6638	0.0971	0.1672	0.5433

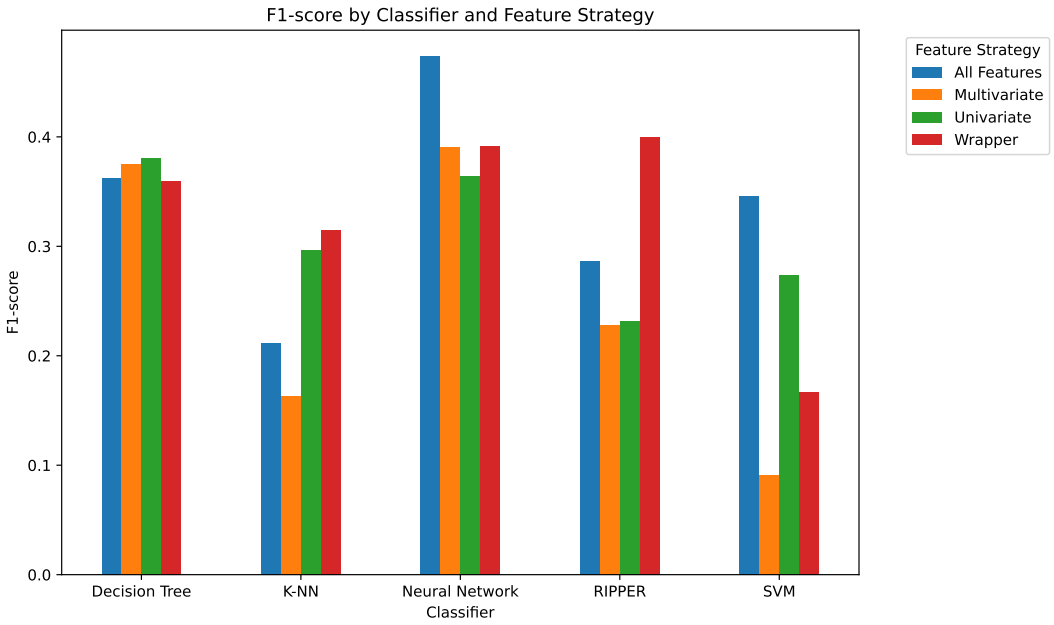


Figure 1: PA1 mean F1-score by classifier and feature-selection strategy.

Table 3: Agreement between descriptive full-data selections at original-variable level. U: univariate; M: multivariate; W: wrapper.

Original variable	U	M	W	Count
BusinessTravel	Yes	Yes	Yes	3
JobInvolvement	Yes	Yes	Yes	3
JobRole	Yes	Yes	Yes	3
MaritalStatus	Yes	Yes	Yes	3
MonthlyIncome	Yes	Yes	Yes	3
OverTime	Yes	Yes	Yes	3
StockOptionLevel	Yes	Yes	Yes	3
Age	Yes	–	Yes	2
JobSatisfaction	Yes	Yes	–	2
NumCompaniesWorked	–	Yes	Yes	2
TotalWorkingYears	Yes	–	Yes	2

4.2 PA2: Probabilistic Classification

4.2.1 All Features

Full-feature Logistic Regression has the highest F1 among the standard PA2 classifiers (0.5373) and the highest AUC (0.8375). Mixed Naive Bayes has the highest recall of all PA2 configurations (0.6453), alongside lower precision and a larger Brier score. Table 4 gives the exact metrics for all four classifiers under each strategy.

4.2.2 Univariate Filter

Mixed Naive Bayes leads this strategy in F1 (0.4600) and maintains relatively high recall (0.6033). QDA improves over its all-feature F1, whereas Logistic Regression declines. Thirteen original predictors recur in all ten folds, including overtime, job level and company tenure.

4.2.3 Multivariate Filter

CFS selects 3–11 original variables per fold (mean 7.8). Job level, overtime and stock-option level appear in all ten subsets. Mixed Naive Bayes leads this strategy in F1 (0.3962), below its all-feature result, while its Brier improves.

4.2.4 Wrapper

Logistic Regression has the highest reduced-feature PA2 F1 (0.4696). Wrapper searches retain roughly 13–15 original predictors on average, depending on the classifier, but none exceeds the strongest full-feature baseline.

4.2.5 Metaclassifiers and Overall Comparison

Stacking obtains the highest PA2 F1 (0.5394) and lowest Brier (0.1846), though its F1 advantage over full-feature Logistic Regression is marginal. AdaBoost has a competitive AUC but a much larger Brier; Bagging has lower F1 and recall.

Table 4 reports all 16 standard-classifier configurations, while Table 5 gives the three meta-classifiers. Across both tables, full-feature Logistic Regression has the highest AUC and Mixed Naive Bayes the highest recall. Figures 2 and 3 contrast F1 with probability-vector error. These rankings use observed cross-validation means and do not establish statistically significant differences.

Table 4: PA2 standard-classifier performance by feature-selection strategy. Entries are ten-fold means; bold indicates the highest F1 within each strategy. AUC is the area under the ROC curve; lower probability-vector Brier is better.

Model	Acc.	Prec.	Rec.	F1	AUC	Brier
All Features						
Logistic Regression	0.8823	0.7344	0.4259	**0.5373**	0.8375	0.1857
Mixed Naive Bayes	0.7986	0.4208	0.6453	0.5083	0.7851	0.2902
LDA	0.8639	0.6740	0.3168	0.4256	0.8146	0.2036
QDA	0.8150	0.4184	0.3755	0.3946	0.7211	0.2786
Univariate						
Mixed Naive Bayes	0.7707	0.3733	0.6033	**0.4600**	0.7633	0.3190
QDA	0.8320	0.4728	0.3924	0.4240	0.7302	0.2628
Logistic Regression	0.8578	0.6676	0.2708	0.3736	0.7919	0.2112
LDA	0.8565	0.6328	0.2658	0.3700	0.7714	0.2239
Multivariate						
Mixed Naive Bayes	0.8388	0.5157	0.3531	**0.3962**	0.7616	0.2386
QDA	0.8395	0.4934	0.2525	0.3259	0.7204	0.2463
LDA	0.8544	0.6246	0.2192	0.3134	0.7428	0.2335
Logistic Regression	0.8551	0.6471	0.2014	0.2997	0.7692	0.2229
Wrapper						
Logistic Regression	0.8714	0.7287	0.3551	**0.4696**	0.8206	0.1976
Mixed Naive Bayes	0.8293	0.4730	0.4087	0.4358	0.7701	0.2400
QDA	0.8361	0.4910	0.3293	0.3848	0.7165	0.2535
LDA	0.8503	0.5810	0.2621	0.3589	0.7844	0.2207

Table 5: PA2 metaclassifier performance. Entries are ten-fold means; lower probability-vector Brier is better.

Model	Acc.	Prec.	Rec.	F1	AUC	Brier
Stacking	0.8830	0.7472	0.4259	0.5394	0.8365	0.1846
AdaBoost	0.8762	0.7758	0.3380	0.4676	0.8314	0.3773
Bagging	0.8551	0.6442	0.2362	0.3407	0.7931	0.2158

Table 6 summarises the dimensionality of each strategy's highest-F1 configuration. Reductions use the corresponding classifier's full-feature count as the reference; original predictors and transformed columns are kept in distinct units.

Table 6: Highest-F1 configuration and dimensionality for each PA1 and PA2 feature-selection strategy. T: transformed columns; O: original predictors. Decimal counts are outer-fold means; reduction is relative to the same classifier's full-feature representation.

Study	Strategy	Highest-F1 model	Selected	Reduction	F1
PA1	All Features	Neural Network	51 T	0.0%	0.4738
PA1	Univariate	Decision Tree	15 T	70.6%	0.3809
PA1	Multivariate	Neural Network	15 T	70.6%	0.3902
PA1	Wrapper	RIPPER	2.6 O	91.3%	0.3996
PA2	All Features	Logistic Regression	30 O	0.0%	0.5373
PA2	Univariate	Mixed Naive Bayes	15 O	50.0%	0.4600
PA2	Multivariate	Mixed Naive Bayes	7.8 O	74.0%	0.3962
PA2	Wrapper	Logistic Regression	14.6 O	51.3%	0.4696

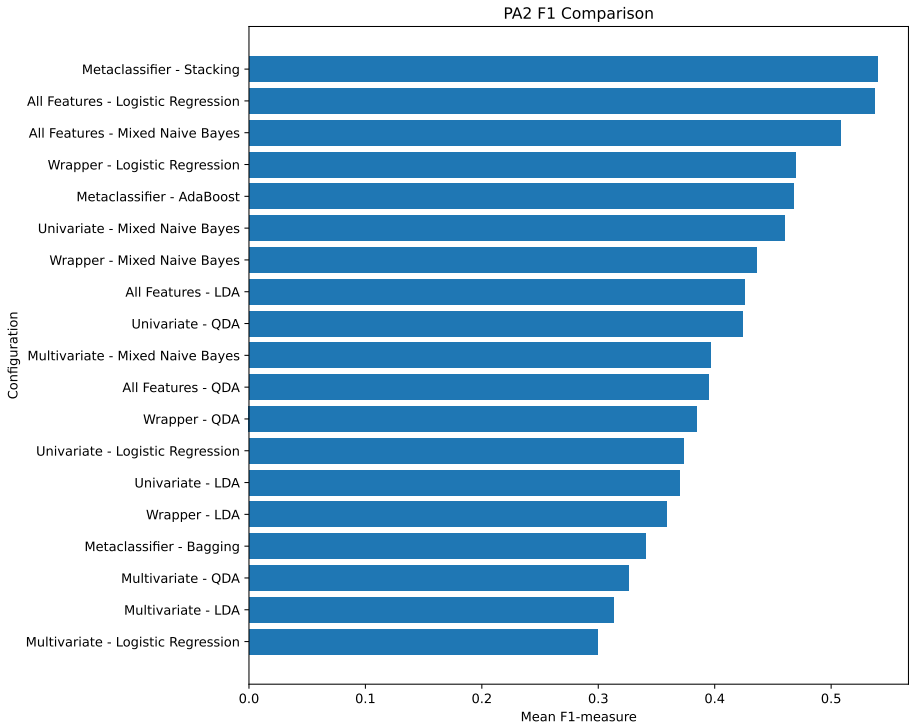


Figure 2: PA2 mean F1 by classifier and strategy. Higher is better.

5 Discussion

5.1 PA1 Performance and Dimensionality

Given the class imbalance in Table 1, accuracy must be read alongside minority-class metrics. The full-feature SVM combines accuracy 0.8653 and precision 0.8363 with recall 0.2241 (Table 2): its positive predictions are relatively precise, but it identifies only a small proportion of employees leaving. The full-feature Neural Network has the highest observed PA1 F1 and balanced accuracy, although recall 0.4219 still indicates substantial missed attrition cases.

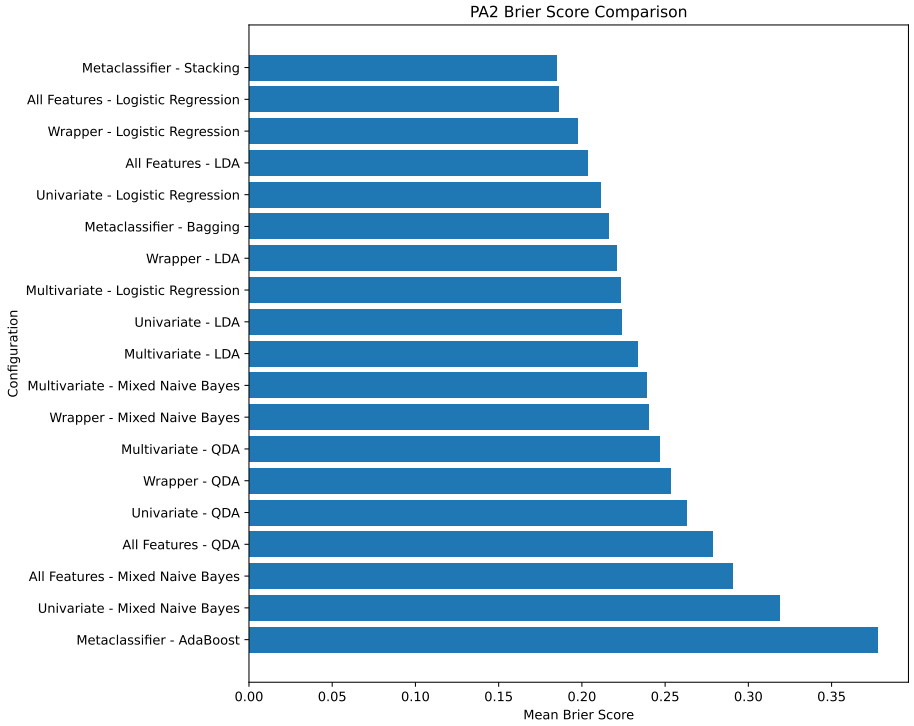


Figure 3: PA2 mean full class-probability-vector Brier score by classifier and strategy. Lower is better.

Selection does not universally improve performance. K-NN benefits from univariate and wrapper selection, while multivariate selection lowers its F1. Removing dimensions changes its neighbourhoods, which may help when useful features are retained; the experiment does not establish this mechanism. Decision Tree improves moderately with the filters. Every reduced Neural Network configuration loses performance relative to its complete representation.

The filters assess feature–target association, with the multivariate filter also penalising redundancy: the univariate subset retains both overtime indicators, whereas the multivariate subset retains only `OverTime_Yes`. For K-NN, Decision Tree, SVM and Neural Network, wrapper additions are scored with a Decision Tree's F1, so the selected representation is not independently optimised for each final classifier. These criteria can favour different subsets. The 70.59% reduction is substantial, but 15 transformed columns need not represent 15 distinct employee characteristics.

RIPPER's rule-based predictions can be inspected through explicit IF–THEN conditions. Its classifier-specific wrapper raises F1 from 0.2866 to 0.3996 and provides the highest reduced-feature F1, while the complete Neural Network remains best overall. The wrapper averages 2.6 original predictors, whereas the filters select 15 transformed columns. Different units and the bounded two-fold/three-step search prevent attributing these differences solely to classifier choice. The overlap tables describe descriptive full-data selector fits, whereas RIPPER's wrapper selections vary across outer folds.

The induced rules describe positive predictions through explicit conjunctions, rather than feature retention alone. For example, the first outer training-fold wrapper model includes the rule `OverTime=Yes` AND `StockOptionLevel=0` AND `JobRole=SalesExecutive`; a matching employee is classified as attrition. Another rule in that same model requires `StockOptionLevel=0` and `JobRole=SalesRepresentative`, without an overtime condition. Thus overtime is not required by every positive rule. Across wrapper folds, overtime is selected in all ten, job role in eight and job level in three; stock-option level appears in two, while company tenure, department and work-life balance each appear in one. These are selections, not condition frequencies or causal effects. Conditions within each rule are joined by AND; rules are joined by OR, with

no matching rule predicting no attrition. Fold-specific rule sets illustrate model behaviour and should not be presented as a single universal full-data rule set.

5.2 Integrated Performance and Probability Quality

Full-feature Logistic Regression in PA2 exceeds PA1's full-feature Neural Network in observed F1, with similar recall (Tables 2 and 4). Its additive log-odds form and default regularisation offer a comparatively simple probabilistic model. Retaining all predictors may preserve jointly useful information, but this experiment does not establish a mechanism. PA1–PA2 comparisons combine classifier and representation differences, so they do not isolate an effect of probabilistic modelling.

Aggressive filtering can discard complementary information. PA2's univariate ranking scores predictors individually, while CFS favours relevance with low redundancy rather than classifier F1. CFS yields compact subsets but may omit jointly useful information. QDA's univariate improvement is consistent with reduced covariance-estimation demands, although it remains below Logistic Regression. The bounded classifier-specific wrapper likewise fails to recover the strongest complete-feature F1. PA1 and PA2 dimensionality reductions use different feature units.

Mixed Naive Bayes detects more minority-class cases at the cost of lower precision and higher probability-vector error. Its conditional-independence assumption may be restrictive for related career and compensation predictors, although this experiment does not establish the cause of its probability error. Higher recall does not imply better probability quality. AdaBoost's competitive AUC but much larger Brier likewise separates ranking discrimination from probability accuracy.

Stacking adds an internal fitting stage yet improves F1 and Brier only marginally over Logistic Regression, with unchanged recall and slightly lower AUC. Its related linear base learners may offer limited complementary information. Without a formal paired comparison, the differences do not establish a meaningful advantage. Full-feature Logistic Regression remains competitive on discrimination, probability quality and simplicity; Mixed Naive Bayes serves a recall-focused objective, while CFS offers compactness. No configuration dominates all objectives.

5.3 Interpretation of Employee Characteristics

Four predictors are selected in at least eight folds by both PA2 filters: `OverTime`, `JobLevel`, `StockOptionLevel` and `YearsAtCompany`. Overtime describes working conditions; job level describes organisational position; stock-option level represents a compensation attribute; and company tenure describes experience within the organisation. Their recurrence indicates that these complementary aspects repeatedly support predictive discrimination under different selection criteria. It does not establish that any attribute causes attrition, nor does selection alone reveal the direction or magnitude of an association. Overtime and stock-option level also appear in all three PA1 descriptive selections.

PA2's stable univariate selections further retain age, job role, involvement, monthly income and career-experience variables, supporting a multidimensional predictive interpretation. Related measures of professional level, compensation and experience should not be interpreted independently. PA1 agreement counts come from separate full-data fits, whereas PA2 frequencies count outer training-fold selections; neither is a causal importance ranking.

The existing descriptive analysis provides context for overtime: attrition is 30.53% among employees with overtime and 10.44% among those without it. These rates support interpreting overtime as associated with attrition-related classification patterns, rather than as a cause of leaving. `Age`, `JobSatisfaction`, `NumCompaniesWorked` and `TotalWorkingYears`, each selected by two strategies, add demographic, satisfaction and career-experience information.

Dummy categories must be interpreted together at original-variable level. For example, `OverTime_Yes` and `OverTime_No` encode the same employee characteristic; different retained

`JobRole` categories still refer to job role. Agreement across methods makes the selected representation easier to discuss, but does not by itself provide a ranked importance measure or explain individual Neural Network predictions.

5.4 Limitations

The IBM dataset is synthetic/fictitious, so these findings should not be treated as evidence about a specific real workforce. Class imbalance remains present and minority-class recall is limited. Hyperparameters and decision thresholds were not optimised; conclusions concern the chosen configurations. PA1 fixes reduced subsets at 15 transformed features; PA2 ranks or searches original predictors, retaining at most 15. Neither setup establishes a globally optimal subset.

Numerical nominal codes in standalone LDA/QDA introduce representation dependence without meaningful ordering. QDA's instability inside stacking illustrates the sensitivity of covariance estimation to the available representation and sample size. PA1's wrapper and PA2's stacking fit preprocessing before their internal folds, as disclosed in Methodology; outer held-out folds remain excluded from all fitting. Cross-validation provides honest estimates for fixed configurations, but choosing the highest observed mean among many configurations may favour sampling variation. No independent external validation or statistical significance claim is provided. Logistic Regression coefficients provide supplementary descriptive insights into feature associations, but they should not be interpreted as causal effects or explanations of individual predictions.

6 Conclusion

PA1 and PA2 address one attrition-prediction problem using stratified cross-validation, with outer held-out data excluded from preprocessing, feature selection and model fitting. The full-feature Neural Network leads PA1 in F1. In PA2, Stacking has the highest observed F1 and lowest Brier, although its gains over full-feature Logistic Regression are marginal; Mixed Naive Bayes has the highest recall.

Feature selection reduces dimensionality and benefits some classifiers but does not systematically improve the strongest complete-feature models. Repeated retention of overtime, job level, stock-option level and company tenure in PA2, together with recurring PA1 characteristics, supports interpretation of predictive associations without causal claims. The practical choice therefore depends on the trade-off between predictive performance, sensitivity to attrition, dimensionality and model complexity.

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